

EDUCATIONPLUS

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A. Joseph Dorairaj

A bridge course is a preparatory one just before the start of a new academic year to help students transition smoothly from school to university. The twin objectives are to fill knowledge gaps and help students acclimatise themselves to a new environment. For many students, bridge courses often revolve around transitions:

to a higher knowledge ecosystem, to another medium of instruction (often from regional language to English), and from rural to urban or semi-urban settings. But, for all, the most crucial is the passage to young adulthood. Problems In many institutions, bridge courses do not yield the desired results. This is because some teachers, fuelled by the notion that they have to give the stu-

dents a head start, try to package the curricula of the first semester into this time. Another issue is that most adopt the same pedagogy of a regular class: the lecture method. Whereas an interactive method would be more suitable for the needs of these students. Also, a bridge course classroom, is heterogeneous in nature. Teachers need to vary their teaching styles and strategies to ca-

ter to the differential abilities of the students. Many institutions do not have a proper curriculum or textbooks for such courses. Even the schedule is tentative. So the faculty have to improvise and, often, do it badly. Bridge courses are meant as much for academics as for socialisation and peer teaching and learning. However, the latter aspect is ignored. Bridge schools should not be confused with summer schools, which are rigorous and intensive programmes and are meant to boost students' domain knowledge.

Strategies All these problems can be overcome by adopting certain efficient strategies. First, the faculty must understand that the objectives of a bridge course and a regular undergraduate programme are different and deploy appropriate pedagogies in the classroom. There should be less teacher-talk and more student-talk, making the classroom student-centric and interactive. Second, the focus must be on academics and social integration. To facilitate this, peer teaching and mentoring, especially by senior students, should be encouraged. Third is the inclusion of fun-filled activities that will effectively help in social integration and, as Krashen argued, make learning meaningful and faster when the affective filter is

low. Finally, a bridge course is a short-term programme. What could not be taught over 12 years of study in terms of domain knowledge and proficiency cannot be achieved in a couple of weeks. So, neither the student nor the faculty should expect miracles. Bridge courses must focus on enhancing the participants' communication skills in English and deepen basic knowledge of the discipline's concepts to wean them away from rote memorisation and acquire knowledge in a systematic manner. This will provide a foundation for their undergraduate programme. When conducted efficiently, bridge courses help students, especially those from disadvantaged backgrounds, to move to a different medium of instruction and also cope with the change to a college environment. They are meant to acclimatise students to different intellectual and physical environments and fill knowledge gaps to some extent. In any rite of passage, the liminal space leading to aggregation is a crucial step and, therefore, bridge course participants should be helped to cross the threshold of liminality and enter the university system.

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OFF THE EDGE Nandini Raman

I am 25 and have six years of full-time experience in insurance claims. Should I prepare for CMAT to pursue a PGDM at the National Insurance Academy, Pune, or for banking exams? Is it advisable to quit my job for a good PGDM? Srijeet

Dear Srijeet, What is your goal? Do you want a frontline managerial role or a structured service-based role? If you want a stable government job with fixed career progression and security, along with a good work-life balance, choose banking. But it comes with a growth ceiling. Leadership exposure is mostly in internal roles. There are transfers. It offers limited flexibility to switch to corporate strategy or analytics later. But if you are looking at a fast-track career growth in insurance or BFSI, a specialised PGDM in Insurance and Risk Management provides you with a strong alumni network in insurance and risk sectors, higher starting packages and access to managerial roles in insurance, reinsurance, and broader BFSI. It also opens doors to corporate finance, analytics, underwriting, and leadership faster than banking. However, cracking the entrance exam is tough; you will need to quit your job to prepare. The tuition fee is high and, while placements are good, they are not guaranteed. Can you manage for two years without the financial base your job provides?

I completed my Master's in Computer Science in the U.S. a year ago, but am concerned about AI's

Clarity of intent is important Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

impact. I am considering a career in elder care abroad. I am 25, empathetic, and enjoy caring for others. Would this be a suitable career choice? Sai

Dear Sai, Elder care is a great option and in constant demand. It is recession-resistant and countries like India, the U.S., Canada, Japan, and Australia have a dire need for good workers to look after their elderly. Some countries offer long-term employment and visa support. The roles require empathy, patience, decision-making, physical presence and constant caregiving. Consider doing a Master's in Social Work for exposure to working with a geriatric population and exposure specific areas that interest you: patients with dementia or Parkinson's disease or palliative care, or working with the elderly in an assisted living or retirement setting. While this can give you high job satisfaction, you also need to be emotionally fit and stable. These roles have a high burnout rate, as they are physically demanding and involve handling sickness and serious illness all the time. Some roles in this field include caregiver or personal support worker, nurse or home health aide, and elderly wellness coordinator or activity manager. To grow in this space, focus on building skills in basic healthcare and first aid (like CPR and emergency response), understanding elder psychology and communication, as well as nutrition, mobility support, and personal care. Certifications such as a nursing assistant or CNA

are highly valuable. Additionally, your background in Computer Science can help you work with elder-care technology like apps and monitoring systems to track health and mobility data, and provide more personalised care. Research country-specific certification requirements (Canada, Australia, the U.S.) and take short-term elder care or nursing assistant courses online.

I am a Class 11 Humanities student (ISC board) interested in studying Archaeology while also preparing for the UPSC. How do I manage preparation for both? Which course at Banaras Hindu University would suit my goals? Sarada

Dear Sarada, Banaras Hindu University (BHU) offers B.A. (Hons) Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology. Admission is via CUET and BHU-UET. Post your B.A., you can do an M.A. Ancient Indian History and Archaeology also at BHU. Archaeology will help with the UPSC preparation. The syllabus involves ancient history in the General Studies Paper 1. It will also offer civilisational understanding for essays and strong analysis and reading skills that help in the Mains. To manage your B.A. and UPSC preparation, focus on your coursework during the week and dedicate at least two hours on the weekend for the UPSC. Archaeology classes are heavy on reading and interpretation, which again is great practice for UPSC reading and writing. A study strategy that blends both goals: for the first two years, work on your B.A. and UPSC foundation. Read NCERT Class 6-12

history textbooks, basic general studies and newspapers. In the last year of your B.A., intensify UPSC prep (especially GS) and consider joining a foundation course (online/offline) if feasible. Start working on the test series and answer writing.

I am in the third year of B.Sc. Physics and want to pursue a Master's in Physics. Are there lucrative job opportunities after graduation? Ansa

Dear Ansa, A typical progression to M.Sc. Physics involves a specialisation in Condensed Matter Physics, Quantum Mechanics, Quantum Computing, Astrophysics, Space Science, Material Science, Nanotechnology, or Computational or Theoretical Physics. After this, you can go for a Ph.D. or an integrated research programme at IISC, TIFR, IITs, ISRO, DRDO. Job opportunities after M.Sc. Physics involve teaching positions in colleges or universities after taking the NET or JRF or in organisations like the ISRO, DRDO, BARC, CSIR. In the private sector, roles are available in data science and analytics, electronics, instrumentation, optics, finance and quant roles. Great opportunities exist in space and defence sector, the Civil Services and in government departments. Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



When change is constant How HEIs can keep pace with Artificial Intelligence, a technology that constantly reinvents itself

Raghav Gupta

Recently Google turned its NotebookLM into a full AI workspace and launched Gemini 3 Flash as the new default model. The open-source world dropped GLM 4.7, which is currently crushing every coding benchmark ever. ChatGPT released GPT 5.2, creating benchmarks in the long content format.

Constant change Artificial Intelligence is no longer an emerging subject. New models, frameworks, tools, and ethical debates surface every day. Yet, most universities operate within a syllabus-driven system where curriculum revisions take years, not months. According to the FICCI-EY-P AI Adoption Survey 2025, 86% of students in Indian higher education institutions already use AI tools in their studies but only about 57% of those institutions have for-

mal AI policies in place. So, how do you teach a technology that reinvents itself every 12-18 months within an academic structure designed for stability? The answer lies in a fundamental rethinking of how AI is taught, assessed, and continuously refreshed within the university ecosystem. First, learning needs to shift from being tool centric to principle centric. To remain competitive, universities need to focus on teaching the general principles of computing. While there may be different tools, the core principle upon which they were developed, how they will work and the concepts behind them, must remain consistent over time. Institutions should, therefore, emphasise the development of algorithmic thinking and decomposing problems; an understanding of both data literacy and statistical reasoning; interpretation of models, their

limitations, and their ethical implications; and the ability to consider a systemic perspective and how students interact with AI. By emphasising these basic tenets, institutions can prepare their students to individually adapt as new technologies are created. The second involves modular and stackable curriculum design. AI education should not be approached as a single block of learning. Institutions may revise short modules, electives and micro-credentials every year to include developments in the AI field, while maintaining their existing curriculum's core structure. This also encourages cross-disciplinary collaboration by incorporating AI components into business, healthcare, humanities or design programs while remaining consistent with how AI operates within these fields. A case study from Zhejiang University in China adopted a dual-module fra-

mework (20-hour AI training + embedded ethics discussions), introduced deep learning models, LLMs, AIGC, LoRA, and ComfyUI while maintaining the original curriculum structure, supported by dedicated technical instructors. It is an example of how phased, modular approaches can enhance student skills without overhauling existing degrees.

Faculty development Third is faculty enablement, an aspect as critical as student curriculum. A quickly evolving field requires ongoing support for faculty development. Universities need to actively support their professors through faculty development programmes that focus on the practical applications of AI, through collaborative teaching models that bring together both practitioners and educators, and through research sabbaticals that allow faculty to work at applied research labs or within industry settings. If educators are up to date with technological advancements, students will also benefit by receiving an education that incorporates these advancements. Finally, universities must see themselves as learning ecosystems, not content providers. In our rapidly changing world, AI is advancing so quickly that the half-life of knowledge is decreasing rapidly, and the education process should not end at graduation. In addition to providing new exciting programmes for graduates, universities should also offer an opportunity to continue learning by providing access to updated modules (the same as a continuing professional education), refresher courses, and emerging research. The institutions that fully embrace this vision will not just be able to keep pace with the rapidly changing technological world, but will also be able to shape it.

The writer is the founder and CEO of FutureSense



# Beyond enrolments

While there is growing confidence in online higher education in India, it's time to ask a crucial question: How many will actually finish what they start?

Rohit Gupta

In 2023, the University Grants Commission (UGC) allowed January admissions for online and distance-learning degree programmes, breaking India's long-standing single-intake academic cycle. The move was intended to expand access for working professionals, mid-career learners, and those who missed the July window. Enrolments have since grown but an uncomfortable question remains largely unasked. How many of these students, especially

those entering through non-traditional cycles, actually graduate?

### Crucial question

Last year, the UGC approved 101 universities and 20 category-I institutions to offer online and distance-learning programmes and the NIELIT Digital University, a national platform intended to democratise access to high-quality digital education, was also launched. But as access widens and enrolments rise, it's time to ask how many will actually finish what they start? India's education data



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tracks enrolments far more closely than completion. At the school level, the picture is clearer. Secondary dropout rates have fallen from 21% in 2013-14 to 13% in 2021-22 but once students enter higher education, the numbers on dropouts are not clearly captured. The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) captures enrolment and infrastructure but offers little visibility on how many students grad-

uate. The details are vaguer for dropout rates in the online education system.

### Defining dropouts

We know that the risk of attrition in online programmes is often higher. The average completion rate for general non-paid online courses is often cited between 10-20% and paid professional certifications around 40-60%. The National Education Policy

(NEP) 2020 further complicates how we define "dropouts" in India now. With multiple entry and exit points and an Academic Bank of Credits, students can pause and resume their studies later. It's a progressive step but one that also risks masking disengagement. Flexibility, while essential, must be matched with mechanisms that guide learners back when they drift. Many learners in India

enrol in online degrees believing they will be easier or faster. When the coursework proves demanding and the support thin, motivation fades.

### Problems faced

The issue often is a lack of peer group and mentorship. On a physical campus, students rely on informal conversations, peer encouragement, and visible accountability. Online, that scaffolding vanishes. Coursera's Drivers of Retention in Online Degree Programmes (2022) found that learners with dedicated mentors were 20% more likely to complete their courses.

For many, infrastructure adds another barrier. Weak internet access, poor interface design, or delayed faculty responses can turn flexibility into frustration. The Commonwealth of Learning has long observed that, in India's distance education system, attrition correlates less with academic ability than with how responsive institutions are when students struggle.

If online education is to fulfil its promise, India has to now shift focus to the issue of retention. One of the first and most important steps is for institutions to track completion rates alongside enrolments to understand and track what is working and not working. Transparency creates pressure to improve and trust among students.

Next is preparation. A short, structured orientation covering digital literacy, time management, and realistic workload expectations will help students know what is expected of them. Many drop out because they misjudge the demands of an online degree.

Most importantly, the human layer must be integrated into the digital system. Assigning mentors, forming small cohorts, and maintaining regular contact can transform retention.

Technology can be leveraged to assist in giving deep learning analytics that can flag when a student stops logging in or submitting assignments

but intervention must still be human. The most successful global models combine predictive tools with personal outreach, blending empathy with efficiency.

Marketing, too, needs a reset. Promising instant employability or "study anytime" convenience oversells the format. Honest communication about effort and support builds more committed learners and long-term credibility.

The NEP's flexible framework and efforts of the UGC and Distance Education Bureau have shifted India's higher education narrative from rigid pathways to lifelong learning and a recognition of the potential of online education. But flexibility without support will not improve learning outcomes. Dropouts are a reminder that systems need to be strengthened. The next milestone to chase for online education is a serious focus on retention.

*Views expressed are personal*

The writer is COO, College Vidya.



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# Knowledge and strategy

How to shift from preparing for board exams to studying for entrance exams

Aditya Shanker  
Raghuwanshi

A curious pattern typically emerges during entrance exam season. Students who performed exceptionally well in board examinations sometimes struggle with competitive tests, while others with average board scores adapt more comfortably. The difference does not lie in intelligence or effort but in the way learning has been approached over the years.

Traditionally, academic preparation has focused on memorising formulas, revising textbook content, and practising answers that align closely with the syllabus. This method works well for board exams, where structured answers and familiarity with chapters determine performance. However, entrance examinations are designed to test concept understanding and effective application to solve unfamiliar problems.

Many students, therefore, find themselves unprepared for exams that prioritise conceptual clarity, analytical thinking, and problem-solving ability. Here are four common mistakes that surface at the end of the board exam phase and how to overcome them.

**Preparation:** While board exams usually test knowledge of the syllabus, entrance exams require using concepts in new situations. A single problem may combine ideas from multiple chapters or expect them to use a concept to arrive at a solution. This approach rewards clarity of thought and the ability to recognise underlying principles quickly. Engineering entrance exams feature high volumes of multiple-choice questions packed into tight windows. Success depends on immediate recognition of the right approach, with the stakes raised by negative marking. Without a rock-solid conceptual base, formulas generally fail when the pressure mounts. Understanding how questions are framed, therefore, becomes the first step.

**Study time:** Another mistake is to equate long study hours with productive learning. In reality, unfocused study sessions lead to fatigue without improving understanding. Using short, focused study blocks and techniques like active recall, concept mapping, and practice problems are far more effective than reading notes. Studying in intervals of 20-25 minutes followed by short breaks helps prevent burnout. When preparation emphasises clarity over duration, students are able to grasp concepts faster and apply them more confidently in exam situations.

**Study structure:** Entrance exam syllabi typically cover concepts taught over multiple academic years. Dividing the syllabus into manageable sections allows students to focus on one concept at a time while ensuring that important topics also receive attention by allocating time according to difficulty and weightage in the exam. Consistent practice through mock tests and practice papers helps students adapt to the entrance exam format and identify areas for improvement.

**Power of revision:** In the race to learn new topics, revision of what has already been studied is often pushed aside, leading to potential gaps in understanding. Regular revision plays a vital role in solidifying conceptual clarity. Entrance exam questions frequently combine ideas from different chapters, making it important to retain a strong command of foundational topics. Creating concise notes, flashcards, or concept maps can streamline revision, while weekly review sessions help reinforce learning and prevent important concepts from fading.

An entrance exam is a test of both knowledge and strategy. The journey is not just about reaching the finish line but also building the skills, mindset, and resilience to excel wherever learning takes you.

The writer is the co-founder and CEO of Masterclass Space.

Supraja Perumal

Indian higher education institutions are getting smarter; courses are getting both global in discourse and digitalised. However, lurking behind this story of progress is a darker reality. Educators today are expected to be researchers, administrators, innovators, counsellors, content creators, and compliance officers all at once. Students, on the other hand, are expected to be competitive and perpetual high performers. The only thing that is not growing at the same rate is the time to pause, reflect or recover.

In 2022, over 13,000 student suicides were reported in India, accounting for nearly 8% of all suicides nationwide (NCRB). The statistics on student suicides and increased levels of anxiety among youth in the country are indicators of a system under strain. Even more concerning is that faculty burnout is now the new challenge for a fragile education infrastructure. A 2024 Global Educator Health Re-

port ranked India among countries with the highest reported levels of teacher burnout.

While most higher education institutions set up counselling centres, wellness cells or grievance mechanisms, these are still reactive. A 2023 Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) survey mentioned that around 45% of college students reported symptoms of anxiety and one in every three had depressive tendencies. These numbers show that the need of the hour is not just reactive measures but rather preventive ones that have to address the concerns leading to fatigue and burnout.

### What can be done

The key is to first make sure that there is a proactive redressal system for teachers that ensures a work-life balance that prioritises mental well-

# The missing measure

Why we need to rethink well-being in education



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being and creates a clear academic calendar that doesn't push them to chase submission deadlines. Flexibility at work is a solution worth looking at.

There is a need for more inclusive mental health awareness camps, listening to academic rigour issues, and setting up functional programmes that encourage students to work on improving the quality of their research

papers, instead of looking at numbers.

Mental health paradigms should be built into the everyday ecosystem of higher education: curriculum, assessment, scheduling, mentoring systems, and workload policies. Just as organisations have infrastructure and accreditation schedules, they must have human sustainability schedules.

Another aspect that needs to be addressed is

# Need for coexistence

Campus experience and career outcomes are not competing priorities. When designed well, they reinforce each other

Chaitanya Chitta

The choice used to be simpler. Pick a good campus, immerse yourself, and trust that the degree will eventually convert into a career. That no longer holds. Students today arrive on campus wondering whether half a decade of education will still make sense in a labour market changing faster than university statutes. Embedded in it are assumptions about jobs, mobility and long-term goals.

### Building readiness

Students now evaluate their educational journey by its outcomes and assess which skills will retain value at graduation, which roles are already contracting, and whether a degree offers mobility across sectors and borders or locks them into a narrow path. Employability now shapes decisions at entry, not exit. The result is a generation less impressed by placement brochures and more interested in how institutions actually build readi-

ness through internships, projects shaped by industry problems, and exposure to experiential learning.

Universities are responding, and curricula are being nudged towards flexibility. Credit-bearing internships are becoming common. Capstone projects are increasingly linked to practical outcomes. Finally, accreditation terminology about skills and results is being examined in classrooms rather than only on paper. But the tension between fixed syllabi and industries that rewrite job descriptions every 18 months remains. The result is a redefinition of what employability now means.

AI's effects on higher education over the next two years will be more pragmatic than dramatic. Faster feedback loops, flexible learning resources, and

more astute academic advice that identifies skill gaps early are the ways that students will see it. Faculty will use it to reconsider assessment, moving away from recall-based tests and towards assignments that call for judgment, creativity, and synthesis. AI is also changing employment. Hybrid capabilities, such as technical fluency combined with context, communication, and decision-making are more valued. This has consequences for how students think about careers and where they pursue them. International education itself is being rewrit-

ten. While the four major study locations – the U.S., the U.K., Canada, and Australia – continue to provide value, depth, and research environments, students are taking into account cost, long-term career mobility, post-study employment prospects, and visa certainty while making decisions. Students want credentials and skills that hold value whether they stay back, return home, or move across regions as opportunities emerge.

This is also why foreign branch campuses and transnational models are gaining attention. The versions that work are not replicas of distant universities transplanted wholesale. They are hybrids with global curricula combined with local industry access, flexible degree pathways, and the ability to move across geographies without disrupting academic or professional momentum.

### Still matters

Amid all this, campus experience still matters. Perhaps more than ever. But its meaning has expanded. Students are not choosing between careers and community. They expect both to coexist. Hackathons double up as hiring pipelines. Student clubs partner with startups. Research projects evolve into ventures. Peer

networks, cultural life, student organisations, and exposure to research continue to be crucial in developing leadership, teamwork, and thinking skills.

Campus experience and career outcomes are not competing priorities. When designed well, they reinforce each other. A strong campus culture builds confidence and curiosity. Clear career pathways give that curiosity direction. Today's learner is not asking universities to guarantee outcomes. They are requesting that educators be truthful about the reality that they are entering and provide curricula that help them manage it.

The institutions gaining student trust today are those that combine the credibility of a campus with the currency of careers. They design internships as curriculum, campuses as innovation environments, and degrees as evolving platforms rather than static credentials. The future of higher education will not be defined by who has the longest legacy or the grandest infrastructure, but by who can most effectively align learning, experience, and outcomes into a single, coherent student journey.

The writer is Senior Vice President, Cintana Education